

Custom Laser Profile Block

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July 6, 2026

This document describes the modifications made to EPOCH's `laser` block to support loading arbitrary laser amplitude and phase profiles from raw binary data files¹. See the EPOCH documentation² for the standard `laser` block parameters that are not covered here.

The custom profile injection feature allows a laser field of the form $E = A \cdot \sin(\omega t + \varphi)$ — with A and φ arbitrary functions of the transverse boundary coordinates and (optionally) time — to be driven entirely from externally generated data files, bypassing EPOCH's built-in analytic profile functions. This is particularly useful when interfacing with external beam propagation codes such as LASY³, or when the target profile cannot be expressed as one of EPOCH's analytic primitives. A Python wrapper for LASY written by the same author can be found here⁴.

The feature is implemented in **epoch2d** (released as epoch_dev v2.0.0) and **epoch3d** (released as epoch_dev v2.1.0). epoch1d is unmodified.

Two modes exist, selected per laser block:

- **Spatiotemporal** (`use_spatiotemporal_profile = T`): the full amplitude $A(\text{transverse}, t)$ is interpolated from file at every time step. In 2D the data is $A(y, t)$; in 3D it is $A(\text{tr1}, \text{tr2}, t)$.
- **Static spatial** (`use_spatiotemporal_profile = F`): a time-independent spatial profile is interpolated onto the boundary once at start-up; the temporal envelope is set analytically in the deck via `t_profile`.

In both modes the phase can also be read from file with `use_phase_from_file = T`, on the same grid as the amplitude.

Note on defaults: when `use_custom_profile = T` and `use_spatiotemporal_profile` is not given, epoch2d defaults to the spatiotemporal mode (T) while epoch3d defaults to the static spatial mode (F). Setting the flag explicitly is recommended.

1 EPOCH2D

An example 2D `laser` block using all custom profile features:

```
begin:laser
  boundary = x_min
  intensity_w_cm2 = 1e22
  lambda = 1.0 * micron
  pol = 0

  use_custom_profile = T
```

¹https://epochpic.github.io/documentation/input_deck/binary_files.html

²https://epochpic.github.io/documentation/input_deck/input_deck_laser.html

³<https://github.com/LASY-org/lasy>

⁴<https://github.com/ZheyuanChen/AELP/tree/main>

```

use_spatiotemporal_profile = T
profile_data_file = amplitude.dat

n_t = 50
n_y = 30
y_min = -10.0 * micron
y_max = 10.0 * micron
t_start = 0.0
t_end = 30e-15

use_phase_from_file = T
phase_data_file = phase.dat
end:laser

```

A 2D custom-profile laser block accepts the following parameters:

use_custom_profile Enable custom profile injection. Must be set to T to activate any of the parameters below. The default is F, which leaves all standard EPOCH profile behaviour unchanged.

use_spatiotemporal_profile When T, the full two-dimensional $A(y, t)$ amplitude is read from a raw binary file and re-interpolated at every time step. When F, a one-dimensional static spatial profile $A(y)$ is read (also raw binary) and interpolated onto the boundary once at start-up; the temporal envelope is then set analytically via **t_profile**. Defaults to T in epoch2d. (The static path's legacy text format of coordinate-value pairs — used up to and including v2.1.0 — is no longer supported.)

profile_data_file Path to the amplitude file. Relative paths resolve from the deck's data directory; absolute paths are used as-is. Defaults to **temporal_spatial_profile.dat** (spatiotemporal) or **spatial_profile.dat** (static) if omitted.

n_t_points / **n_t** Number of time points in the profile array. Mandatory when **use_spatiotemporal_profile** = T.

n_transverse_points / **n_y** Number of transverse spatial points in the profile array (≥ 2). Mandatory whenever **use_custom_profile** = T (both modes).

profile_transverse_min / **y_min** Minimum transverse coordinate of the profile grid (metres). Mandatory whenever **use_custom_profile** = T. (For a laser on **y_min**/**y_max** the transverse axis is physically x ; the **y_min** alias name is kept for backward compatibility, but the boundary-agnostic **profile_transverse_min** reads better there.)

profile_transverse_max / **y_max** Maximum transverse coordinate of the profile grid (metres). Mandatory whenever **use_custom_profile** = T.

t_start, **t_end** Start and end times of the profile grid (seconds). These reuse EPOCH's standard laser elements; the profile time axis runs from **t_start** to **t_end** with **n_t** uniformly spaced points. Outside this window the laser is inactive.

use_phase_from_file When T, the phase is also read from file: on the spatiotemporal path $\varphi(y, t)$ is re-interpolated each time step; on the static path $\varphi(y)$ is interpolated once at start-up. Any **phase** = ... expression in the deck is ignored. Defaults to F, in which case the phase is set as normal via the **phase** deck element.

phase_data_file Path to the raw binary phase file (radians). Follows the same path resolution as **profile_data_file**. The phase file must lie on the same grid as the amplitude file (same **n_t**, **n_y**, bounds, **t_start**, **t_end**). Defaults to **phase_profile.dat** if omitted.

2 EPOCH3D

In 3D the boundary plane has two transverse axes, so the grid declaration uses two transverse point counts and two pairs of bounds. The boundary-agnostic names are `tr1` and `tr2`, whose physical meaning depends on the boundary the laser is attached to:

Boundary	tr1 axis	tr2 axis
<code>x_min/x_max</code>	y	z
<code>y_min/y_max</code>	x	z
<code>z_min/z_max</code>	x	y

An example 3D laser block (spatiotemporal, amplitude + phase, on `x_min`, written with the axis-named aliases):

```
begin:laser
  boundary = x_min
  intensity_w_cm2 = 1e22
  lambda = 1.0 * micron
  pol = 0

  use_custom_profile = T
  use_spatiotemporal_profile = T
  profile_data_file = amplitude.dat

  n_y_points = 48
  n_z_points = 40
  n_t_points = 16
  y_min = -8.0 * micron
  y_max = 8.0 * micron
  z_min = -8.0 * micron
  z_max = 8.0 * micron
  t_start = 0.0
  t_end = 60e-15

  use_phase_from_file = T
  phase_data_file = phase.dat
end:laser
```

The same block written with the boundary-agnostic names (useful for decks generated by boundary-independent tooling):

```
n_tr1 = 48
n_tr2 = 40
n_t = 16
tr1_min = -8.0 * micron
tr1_max = 8.0 * micron
tr2_min = -8.0 * micron
tr2_max = 8.0 * micron
```

A 3D custom-profile laser block accepts the following parameters (in addition to `use_custom_profile`, `use_spatiotemporal_profile`, `profile_data_file`, `use_phase_from_file`, `phase_data_file`, `t_start` and `t_end`, which behave exactly as in 2D):

`n_transverse1_points` / `n_tr1` Number of points along the first transverse axis (see the table above). Mandatory (≥ 2) whenever `use_custom_profile = T`.

`n_transverse2_points / n_tr2` Number of points along the second transverse axis. Mandatory (≥ 2) whenever `use_custom_profile = T`.

`n_t_points / n_t` Number of time points. Mandatory (≥ 2) when `use_spatiotemporal_profile = T`; ignored on the static spatial path.

`profile_transverse1_min / tr1_min, profile_transverse1_max / tr1_max` Bounds of the profile grid along the first transverse axis (metres). Mandatory whenever `use_custom_profile = T`.

`profile_transverse2_min / tr2_min, profile_transverse2_max / tr2_max` Bounds along the second transverse axis (metres). Mandatory whenever `use_custom_profile = T`.

`n_{x,y,z}_points / n_{x,y,z}, {x,y,z}_min, {x,y,z}_max` Axis-named aliases for the point counts and bounds above. These are resolved to `tr1` or `tr2` according to the boundary table, so a deck for an `x_min` laser can say `n_y_points/n_z_points` and `y_min...z_max` naturally. Naming the propagation axis (e.g. `n_x_points` on an `x_min` laser) is an error — EPOCH reports the offending element and line and suggests the transverse or boundary-agnostic names.

As in epoch2d, the static spatial path uses the raw binary format (the pre-v2.1.0 text format with embedded coordinates is no longer read) and supports `use_phase_from_file`: the phase plane is interpolated onto the boundary once at start-up alongside the amplitude.

3 File Format

All data files are raw binary with no embedded header. Shape and grid bounds are declared entirely in the deck (see above). This matches EPOCH’s documented binary-file convention used elsewhere in the code (e.g. `particles_from_file`). EPOCH checks the file size against the declared shape at load time and aborts with the expected and actual byte counts if they disagree. Note that the size check cannot detect a transposed array of the same total size — the axis ordering below must be respected.

Each file contains an array of 64-bit IEEE 754 floating point values (the same precision as EPOCH’s `REAL(num)` type), written in Fortran-compatible column-major order:

- **2D spatiotemporal** $A(y, t)$: transverse y fastest-varying, time slowest. $n_y \times n_t$ values.
- **2D static spatial** $A(y)$: a single line of n_y values.
- **3D spatiotemporal** $A(\text{tr1}, \text{tr2}, t)$: `tr1` fastest-varying, then `tr2`, time slowest. $n_{\text{tr1}} \times n_{\text{tr2}} \times n_t$ values.
- **3D static spatial** $A(\text{tr1}, \text{tr2})$: `tr1` fastest-varying. $n_{\text{tr1}} \times n_{\text{tr2}}$ values.

All grids must be uniform; EPOCH reconstructs the axes from the declared bounds and point counts (`np.linspace` on the Python side). Amplitude values should be normalised to the range $[0, 1]$; EPOCH multiplies by the peak field derived from `intensity_w_cm2` (or `amp`). Phase values are in radians and are used directly — EPOCH adds no constant offset.

Interpolation is linear in every axis (bilinear for 2D spatiotemporal and 3D static, trilinear for 3D spatiotemporal). On the spatiotemporal path, positions outside the declared transverse bounds return **zero** amplitude and phase; on the static paths, positions outside the file grid are **clamped** to the edge values. In either case the profile grid should comfortably cover the boundary region the laser is meant to illuminate.

3.1 Python generators

The Fortran column-major layouts above correspond to NumPy arrays in default C (row-major) order with the axes reversed, written with `.tofile()` — **no transpose is needed** in either dimension:

File	NumPy shape (C order)
2D spatiotemporal	(n_t, n_y)
2D static spatial	$(n_y,)$
3D spatiotemporal	(n_t, n_{tr2}, n_{tr1})
3D static spatial	(n_{tr2}, n_{tr1})

2D example:

```
import numpy as np

N_T   = 50
N_Y   = 30
Y_MIN, Y_MAX = -10e-6, 10e-6
T_START, T_END = 0.0, 30e-15

y = np.linspace(Y_MIN, Y_MAX, N_Y)
t = np.linspace(T_START, T_END, N_T)

# meshgrid with indexing="ij" gives arr[t_index, y_index]
Tg, Yg = np.meshgrid(t, y, indexing="ij")

# --- fill amplitude (values in [0, 1]) ---
t0, tau = 15e-15, 5e-15
w0 = 3e-6
amplitude = np.exp(-((Tg - t0) / tau)**2) * np.exp(-(Yg / w0)**2)

assert amplitude.shape == (N_T, N_Y)
amplitude.astype(np.float64).tofile("amplitude.dat")

# --- fill phase (values in radians) ---
phase = np.zeros((N_T, N_Y)) # flat phase for a plane wave
phase.astype(np.float64).tofile("phase.dat")
```

3D example (for an x_min laser, so tr1 = y and tr2 = z):

```
import numpy as np

N_Y, N_Z, N_T = 48, 40, 16          # n_tr1, n_tr2, n_t in the deck
Y_MIN, Y_MAX = -8e-6, 8e-6
Z_MIN, Z_MAX = -8e-6, 8e-6
T_START, T_END = 0.0, 60e-15

y = np.linspace(Y_MIN, Y_MAX, N_Y)
z = np.linspace(Z_MIN, Z_MAX, N_Z)
t = np.linspace(T_START, T_END, N_T)

# indexing="ij" gives arr[t_index, z_index, y_index] = (n_t, n_tr2, n_tr1)
Tg, Zg, Yg = np.meshgrid(t, z, y, indexing="ij")

t0, tau = 30e-15, 10e-15
w0 = 3e-6
```

```

amplitude = (np.exp(-((Tg - t0) / tau)**2)
             * np.exp(-(Yg**2 + Zg**2) / w0**2))

assert amplitude.shape == (N_T, N_Z, N_Y)
amplitude.astype(np.float64).tofile("amplitude.dat")

phase = np.zeros((N_T, N_Z, N_Y))
phase.astype(np.float64).tofile("phase.dat")

```

4 Phase Convention

EPOCH injects the field as:

$$E \propto \text{profile} \cdot \sin(\omega t + \text{phase}) \quad (1)$$

where ωt (the carrier phase) is accumulated internally by EPOCH. The phase file must therefore contain only the slowly varying envelope phase, not the carrier. This applies identically in 2D and 3D.

When using a complex envelope from LASY (where the physical field is $E = \text{Re}[E \cdot \exp(-i\omega_0 t)] = |E| \cdot \cos(\omega_0 t - \varphi)$), the required conversion is:

$$\text{phase_epoch} = -(\text{phase_lasy} - \phi_{\text{ref}}) - \text{gouy_phase} \quad (2)$$

where $\phi_{\text{ref}} = \angle E(\text{on axis}, t = t_{\text{peak}})$ is the on-axis phase at peak time (which removes the arbitrary global piston phase introduced by the propagator), and `gouy_phase` pins the result to EPOCH's carrier convention. A $\pi/2$ offset converts $\cos \rightarrow \sin$ but as a constant it does not affect field shape — the sign and reference subtraction are what matter physically.

See `PHASE_INJECTION.md` (in the `epoch_dev` repository) for a detailed derivation and validation, including a description of the 137% error that results from omitting the reference subtraction.

5 Two-Channel Polarisation

Two custom-file laser blocks on the same boundary with `pol = 0` and `pol = 90` inject into the two transverse polarisation channels independently (e.g. `Ey` and `Ez` for an `x_min` laser):

```

begin:laser
  boundary = x_min
  ...
  pol = 0
  profile_data_file = amplitude_H.dat  # drives Ey
  ...
end:laser

begin:laser
  boundary = x_min
  ...
  pol = 90
  profile_data_file = amplitude_V.dat  # drives Ez
  ...
end:laser

```

Each block declares its own grid and carries independent amplitude and phase data — the file data is stored per laser block, so there is no aliasing between the two channels even if the grids differ. The `cos/sin(pol.angle)` channel split is identical in every boundary routine of `epoch2d` and `epoch3d`, so the same pattern works in 3D. (The two-channel configuration has been validated end-to-end in 2D; the 3D per-laser storage is the same design, built in from the start.)

6 Current Limitations

- **epoch1d** has no custom-profile support.
- All file grids must be **uniform**; non-uniform coordinate axes are not supported.
- Memory: in **3D**, each MPI rank *can* store only the slab of the spatiotemporal array covering its own patch of the laser boundary (plus a one-cell margin) rather than the full plane, with loading streamed one time-slice at a time. This is now the default behaviour for a static domain decomposition: `use_pre_balance` defaults to `T` in `epoch3d` and triggers a one-off startup load balance that can move a rank’s local patch, so the file load for a spatiotemporal laser is deferred past that rebalance and windowed against the settled domain instead of being sized too early. Per-rank cost is then roughly $(\text{local patch fraction}) \times n_{\text{tr1}} \times n_{\text{tr2}} \times n_t \times 8$ bytes. The full plane is still stored on every rank when the domain cannot be considered static: `use_balance = T` (dynamic load balancing keeps redistributing cells for the whole run) or a moving window on a `y/z`-boundary laser (its `tr1` axis is `x`, which the window shifts). In **2D** the (small) full array is always broadcast to every rank.
- The 3D implementation (`epoch_dev v2.1.0`) has been verified functionally (loading, axis-ordering, error paths); a quantitative field-level benchmark in 3D (matching the 2D LASY validation) has not yet been run.